Title: Explainable AI Techniques for Student Academic Performance Analytics: A Comparative Study

Domain

Education Analytics

Dataset

1. UCI Student Performance Dataset (academic, demographic, and social factors) https://archive.ics.uci.edu/dataset/320/student+performance

2. xAPI Educational Dataset (learning management system behavioral data) https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/aljarah/xAPI-Edu-Data

3. Open University Learning Analytics Dataset (OULAD) (large-scale higher education learning analytics) https://research.stem.open.ac.uk/ouanalyse/

Abstract

Educational institutions generate large volumes of academic, demographic, and behavioral data that can be utilized to understand student learning patterns and predict academic performance. However, conventional predictive models often function as black-box systems, providing accurate predictions without explaining the factors influencing those outcomes. This lack of interpretability limits the confidence of educators and academic administrators in adopting data-driven decision-making. To address this challenge, this project proposes an Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI)-based framework for Student Academic Performance Analytics by integrating comprehensive Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA), machine learning, and explainability techniques.

The proposed framework utilizes three widely recognized benchmark datasets: the UCI Student Performance Dataset, xAPI Educational Dataset, and the Open University Learning Analytics Dataset (OULAD). Initially, the datasets undergo data preprocessing, including missing value handling, categorical data encoding,

and normalization to improve data quality and consistency. A detailed Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) is then performed to gain meaningful insights through dataset overview, data quality assessment, descriptive statistics, missing value analysis, duplicate record detection, outlier detection, univariate, bivariate, and multivariate analyses, correlation analysis, feature engineering, and feature selection.

Following preprocessing and EDA, multiple machine learning algorithms, namely Logistic Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, XGBoost, and CatBoost, are trained and evaluated for predicting student academic performance. The performance of these models is assessed using standard evaluation metrics, including Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, and ROC analysis. To enhance transparency and interpretability, the framework incorporates SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) and LIME (Local Interpretable Model-agnostic Explanations), enabling both global and local explanations of model predictions. These techniques help identify the most influential features affecting student performance, thereby making the prediction process understandable to educators and stakeholders.

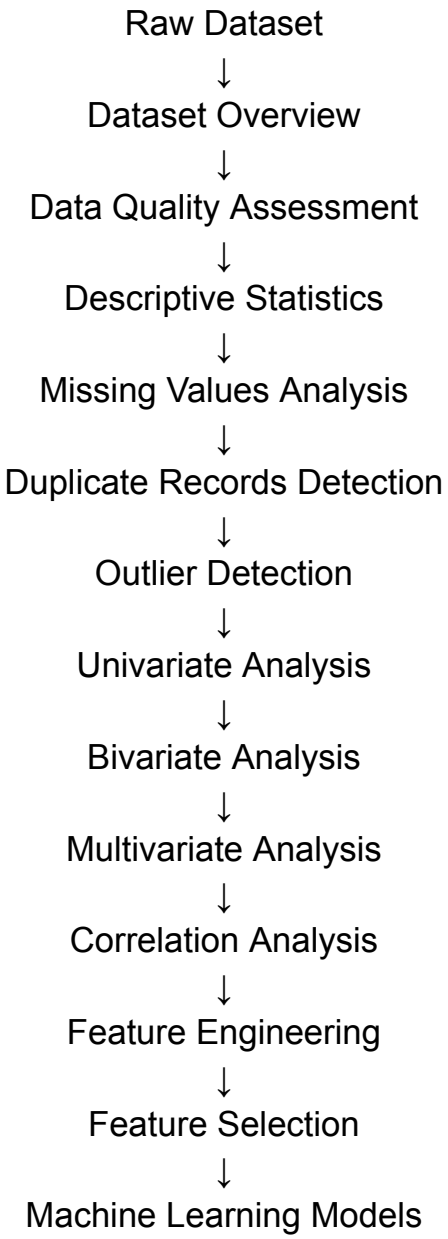
Furthermore, the analytical results are presented through interactive visualizations such as heatmaps, boxplots, feature importance graphs, and dashboards, facilitating effective interpretation of the data and model outcomes. Finally, a comparative analysis is conducted across all machine learning models to determine the most effective and explainable approach for student performance prediction.
The proposed research framework combines educational data mining, learning analytics, machine learning, and explainable AI into a unified analytical pipeline. The project aims not only to achieve high predictive performance but also to provide transparent and interpretable insights that support evidence-based academic interventions, student success strategies, and informed educational decision-making.

Approach

Data Analytics

EDA (Exploratory Data Analysis)

EDA Flow Diagram:



EDA Techniques to Implement (12+ Techniques):

#	Technique	Purpose	Visualization
1	Dataset Overview	Understand data structure	.info(), .describe()
2	Data Quality Assessment	Check data integrity	Quality reports
3	Descriptive Statistics	Statistical summary	Summary tables
4	Missing Value Analysis	Identify gaps	Heatmap, bar plots
5	Duplicate Records	Remove redundancy	Detection report
6	Outlier Detection	Identify anomalies	Boxplots, Z-score
7	Univariate Analysis	Single variable distribution	Histograms, KDE plots
8	Bivariate Analysis	Two-variable relationships	Scatter plots, pair plots
9	Multivariate Analysis	Multi-variable patterns	PCA, pair plots
10	Correlation Analysis	Feature relationships	Correlation matrix, heatmap
11	Feature Engineering	Create new features	Domain-driven creation
12	Feature Selection	Select optimal features	Importance ranking

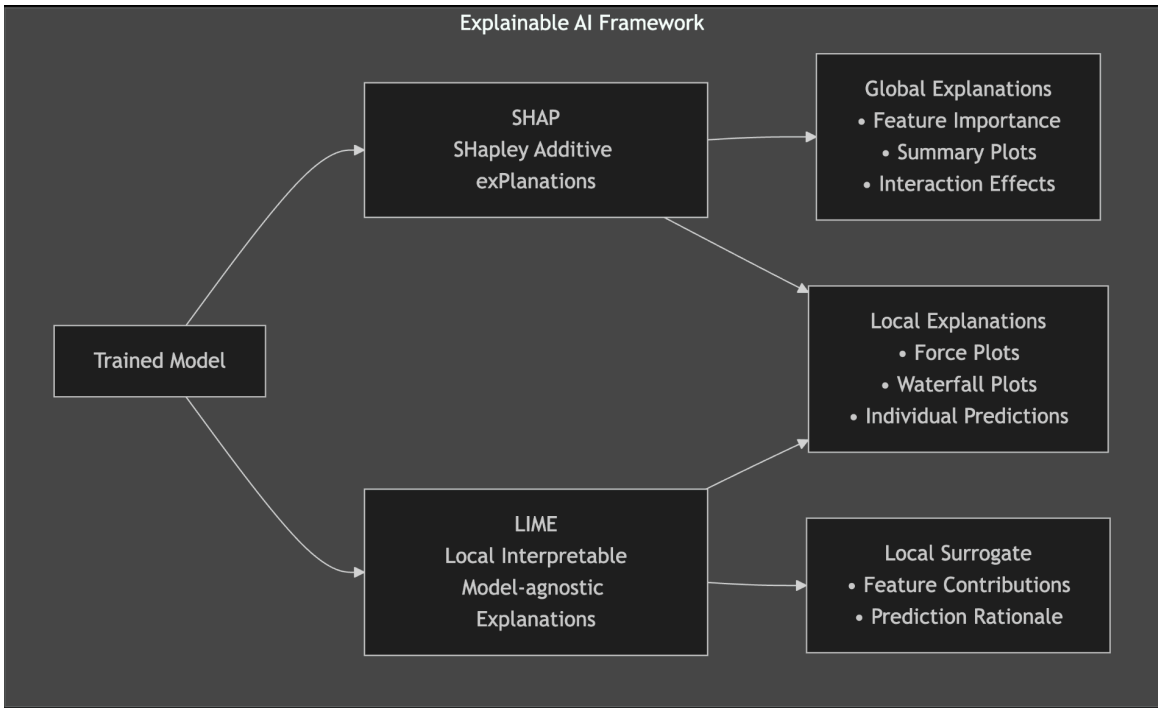
Preprocessing

- Missing Values
- Encoding
- Normalization
- Class Imbalance
- Train-Test Split

ML Models

- Decision Tree
- Random Forest
- XGBoost
- CatBoost
- Logistic Regression

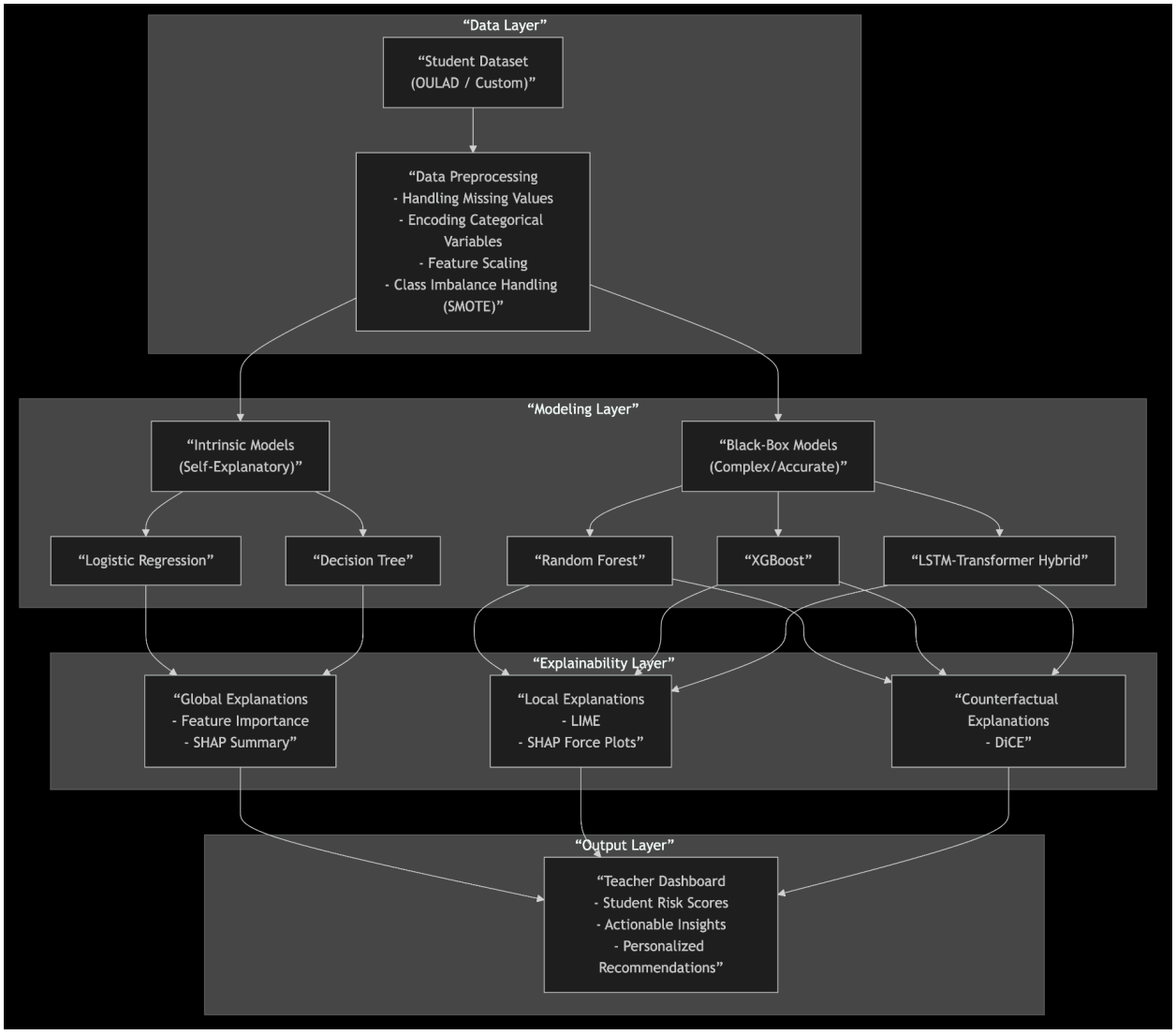
Explainability



Visualization

- Heatmap
- Boxplot
- Feature Importance
- Dashboard
- Force Plot
- ROC Curve
- Confusion Matrix
- Learning Curves

Architectural Diagram



Comparative Analysis

Models

1. Logistic Regression
2. Decision Tree
3. Random Forest
4. XGBoost
5. CatBoost

Evaluation Metrics

1. Accuracy
2. Precision
3. Recall
4. F1-Score
5. ROC-AUC

Comparison Matrix

- Logistic Regression: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, ROC-AUC
- Decision Tree: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, ROC-AUC
- Random Forest: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, ROC-AUC
- XGBoost: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, ROC-AUC
- CatBoost: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, ROC-AUC

Research Pipeline

Phase 1: Data Collection
Benchmark Datasets (UCI + XAPI + OULAD)
↓
Data Cleaning & Preprocessing

Phase 2: Exploratory Data
EDA Pipeline (12+ Techniques)
↓
Feature Engineering
↓
Feature Selection

Phase 3: Modeling
Train-Test Split (80:20)
↓
ML Models (LogReg, DT, RF, XGB, CatBoost)

Phase 4: Evaluation & XAI

Performance Evaluation (Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1, ROC)
↓
Explainable AI (SHAP + LIME)

Phase 5: Output
Visualization Dashboard (Streamlit/Gradio)
↓
Comparative Analysis
↓
Research Conclusions

Implementation Roadmap

Week	Activities	Deliverables
Week 1	Data Collection & Preprocessing	Cleaned datasets, initial EDA
Week 2	Complete EDA Pipeline	EDA report, visualizations
Week 3	ML Model Training	Trained models, initial results
Week 4	XAI Implementation (SHAP + LIME)	Explanations, visualizations
Week 5	Dashboard & Comparative Analysis	Working dashboard, final report

Technology Stack

Category	Tools/Libraries
Data Processing	Pandas, NumPy, Scikit-learn
EDA & Visualization	Matplotlib, Seaborn, Plotly
Machine Learning	Scikit-learn, XGBoost, CatBoost
Explainable AI	SHAP, LIME
Dashboard	Streamlit (or Gradio)

Notebook	Jupyter/Google Colab

Team Information

Roll Number: 2420030371 Name: Ramayanam Vaishnavi
Roll Number: 2420030033 Name: Totha Usha Sri Sai
Roll Number: 2420030551 Name: Naru Mokshita